

Passages - The Myth of Sisyphus

What is called a reason for living is also an excellent reason for dying

Beginning to think is beginning to be undermined.

In a sense, and as in melodrama, killing yourself amounts to confessing. It is confessing that life is too much for you or that you do not understand it.

In a universe suddenly divested of illusions and lights, man feels an alien, a stranger. His exile is without remedy since he is deprived of the memory of a lost home or the hope of a promised land.

We get into the habit of living before acquiring the habit of thinking.

A man defines himself by his make-believe as well as by his sincere impulses.

Mere 'anxiety', as Heidegger says, is at the source of everything.

Men, too, secrete the inhuman. At certain moments of lucidity, the mechanical aspect of their gestures, their meaningless pantomime make silly everything that surrounds them.

The mind's deepest desire, even in its most elaborate operations, parallels man's unconscious feelings in the face of his universe: it is an insistence upon familiarity, an appetite for clarity.

Understanding the world for a man is reducing it to the human, stamping it with his seal.

So long as the mind keeps silent in the motionless world of its hopes, everything is reflected and arranged in the unity of its nostalgia. But with its first move this world cracks and tumbles: an infinite number of shimmering fragments is offered to the understanding. We must despair of ever reconstructing the familiar, calm surface which would give us peace of heart. With the exception of professional rationalists, today people despair of true knowledge. If the only significant history of human thought were to be written, it would have to be the history of its successive regrets and its impotences.

For ever I shall be a stranger to myself. In psychology as in logic, there are truths but no truth. They reveal a nostalgia at the same time as an ignorance.

Just as there are days when, under the familiar face of a woman, we see as a stranger her we had loved months or years ago, perhaps we shall come even to desire what suddenly leaves us so alone.

This very heart which is mine will for ever remain indefinable to me.

A stranger to myself and to the world, armed solely with a thought that negates itself as soon as it asserts, what is this condition in which I can have peace only by refusing to know and to live, in which the appetite for conquest bumps into walls that defy its assaults? To will is to stir up paradoxes.

Everything is ordered in such a way as to bring into being that poisoned peace produced by thoughtlessness, lack of heart or fatal renunciations.

The absurd is born of this confrontation between the human need and the unreasonable silence of the world.

The important thing, as Abbe Galiani said to Mme d'Epainay, is not to be cured, but to live with one's ailments.

It is that divorce between the mind that desires and the world that disappoints, my nostalgia for unity, this fragmented universe and the contradiction that binds them together.

He is asked to leap. All he can reply is that he doesn't fully understand, that it is not obvious. Indeed, he does not want to do anything but what he fully understands. He is assured that this is the sin of pride, but he does not understand the notion of sin; that perhaps hell is in store, but he has not enough imagination to visualize that strange future; that he is losing immortal life, but that seems to him an idle consideration. An attempt is made to get him to admit his guilt. He feels innocent. To tell the truth, that is all he feels - his irreparable innocence. This is what allows him everything. Hence what he demands of himself is to live solely with what he knows, to accommodate himself to what is and to bring in nothing that is not certain. He is told that nothing is. But this at least is a certainty.

I understand then why the doctrines that explain everything to me also debilitate me at the same time. They relieve me of the weight of my own life and yet I must carry it alone.

Suicide is a repudiation. The absurd man can only drain everything to the bitter end, and deplete himself. The absurd is his

extreme tension which he maintains constantly by solitary effort, for he knows that in that consciousness and in that day-to-day revolt he gives proof of his only truth which is defiance.

Being aware of one's life, one's revolt, one's freedom, and to the maximum, is living, and to the maximum.

Don Juan does not think of 'collecting women.

He exhausts their number and with them his chances of life. 'Collecting amounts to being capable of living off one's past. But he rejects regret, that other form of hope. He is incapable of looking at portraits.

There is no noble love but that which recognizes itself to be both short lived and exceptional. All those deaths and all those rebirths gathered together as in a sheaf, make up for Don Juan the flowering of his life. It is his way of giving and of vivifying.

Half a man's life is spent in implying, in turning away, and in keeping silent. Here the actor is the intruder. He breaks the spell chaining that soul, and at last the passions can rush on to their stage. They speak in every gesture; they live only through shouts and cries. Thus the actor creates his characters for display. He outlines or sculptures them and slips into their imaginary form, transfusing his blood into their phantoms.

'Art and nothing but art,' said Nietzsche; 'we have art in order not to die of the truth.'

Creating is living doubly

To think is first of all to create a world (or

to limit one's own world, which comes to the same thing).

Perhaps the great work of art has less importance in itself than in the ordeal it demands of a man and the opportunity with which it provides him of overcoming his phantoms and approaching a little closer to his naked reality.

When the images of earth cling too tightly to memory, when the call of happiness becomes too insistent, it happens that melancholy rises in man's heart.

The struggle itself towards the heights is enough to fill a man's heart. One must imagine Sisyphus happy.